imperial family he chronicled and adored – Abul Fazl writes with an adorning pen. Gulbadan Begum, Babur's daughter and author of the *Humayun-nama*, was in Lahore at this time, and she remembers it very differently. By Gulbadan's account, it was Humayun who wrote to Sher Shah, pleading for Lahore. After all, he wrote, 'I have left you the whole of Hindustan.'

The Afghan was unmoved. 'I have left you Kabul,' was his frosty reply. 'You should go there.'

Humayun's messenger, realizing that Sher Shah meant business, sent a runner to alert the emperor, who decamped immediately. 'It was like the Day of Resurrection,' writes Gulbadan, a fearful scramble in which people left all they had except their money. Then, perhaps in hope of a sudden change of fortune, or perhaps unable to believe the end had come, Humayun pitched his tents across the Ravi river to the west of Lahore. Three days later, Sher Shah's envoy arrived – and Gulbadan writes that it was Humayun, not Kamran, who arranged a reception for him. Worse, he even composed a bit of verse for the victorious Afghan:

Although one's image be shown in the mirror,
It remains always apart from one's self.
It is wonderful to see one's self in another form:
This marvel will be the work of God.[19]

For all the sunny optimism of his couplets, Humayun could hardly have thought it 'wonderful' to have Sher Shah mirror his accession; and if, indeed, the padishah did bring himself to look at his reflection, he would have seen a failure that no amount of philosophizing would separate from his own self. It may be that Humayun went to sleep a defeated and lonely man that night, and in that sorrowful state, he had a dream. An old man came to him, dressed in green, and told him to cheer up.

'Do not grieve,' said the vision, and gave Humayun the staff he held in his hand.

'Who are you?' asked Humayun.

'I am Ahmad of Jam,' said the old man, 'and God shall give you a son of my blood. You will name him Jalaluddin Muhammad Akbar.'[20]

For some days, an unfamiliar optimism animated Humayun's camp. One of his wives, Bibi Gunwar, was in an advanced stage of pregnancy; would